

Augustine contra Donatistas 401

Contra epistulam Parmeniani III.4.23–24 — SECURUS IUDICAT ORBIS TERRARUM (c. 400; CSEL 51, pp. 128–131)

23. But the blindness of men is beyond belief, and I simply do not know how it could be believed that there is such perversity in men, were it not laid bare by the trial of their own words and deeds that they hold the eyes of their heart so shut that, though they cite the testimonies of Holy Scripture, they do not observe in the deeds of the prophets how the words of the prophets are to be understood. Jeremiah said: *what have the chaff to do with the wheat?* Would he himself withdraw from the chaff of his people, among whom he was uttering all those true sayings? Isaiah said: *depart, depart, go out thence and touch not the unclean thing.* Why did he himself, in that people, touch in one congregation with them the uncleanness he was so gravely rebuking? Let them read how many things, and how vehemently and truthfully, he spoke against the wicked of his people, from whom nevertheless he separated himself by no bodily severance. David said: *I have not sat in the council of vanity, and with the doers of wickedness I will not go in; I have hated the assembly of the most wicked, and with the impious I will not sit.* Let them read what men he himself tolerated in his times among that people — he who paid such honour to the mystical sacrament of anointing that he did not despise it even in the utterly wicked Saul, nay, so venerated it that he could not possibly do more. Were we to set their own words against their deeds, would they not answer us: ‘We plainly had no fellowship of heart with such men, nor did we touch the unclean thing where contact can defile — that is, by consent and by the approval of conscience we withdrew and went out from them; for not only did we not do such things, but neither were we silent toward those who did?’ But these seditious and mad men, who [[p. 129]] seek defences for their acts of severance out of the oracles of the prophets — it remains for them, in their raving impiety, to arraign, out of the prophetic words, the morals of the prophets. Will they say this: that in those times it was not permitted to the just to withdraw from an evil people, but in these times it is permitted? What could be said more perversely than that in that age the good ought not to be bodily separated from the wicked, when many sacraments were bidden to be bodily observed, but that now bodily separation is necessary, when those things are already observed spiritually?
24. Woe to the blind leaders and the blind followers! Do they not fear, when they say such things, that perhaps — through so vast a breadth of the world over which the faith and name of Christ has been spread, before these men separated themselves — in some part of the earth most remote from the African regions certain just men had already done this very thing, while these men were meanwhile living in the contagion of the uncleanness those others had fled? For who assures them, who makes them secure, that — if such a separation from the wicked must be made — before it was made by these men it was never made so far away that the Africans were wholly

unaware of it, just as to the peoples of those farthest lands the party of Donatus is utterly unknown? Perhaps they say that what they did not know could not harm them. Then in the same way what is done in Africa cannot harm those lands, since they do not know of it — even if these men were speaking the truth in what they lie about the crimes of the Africans. But if they say it could not have been hidden, if it happened, then let them now say, throughout all the parts of the earth, how many schisms have taken place. It is too much that I ask: in Africa itself let the Donatists of Carthage, or whoever are in the neighbourhood of Carthage, say how many parties have been made throughout Numidia and Mauretania out of that very [[p. 130]] party of Donatus. The causes of all of these they ought surely to know, lest perhaps some just men in their own regions shunned the society and assembly of the wicked and went out from them, that they might not touch the unclean thing, that they might not go in with the doers of wickedness — lest perhaps these men, some years ago now, in some corner of Numidia or Mauretania, when the wheat separated itself, remained behind as chaff, and they do not know it. But whence are they secure, save that they hold it certain that they could not have been good who separated themselves from the unity of the communion of Donatus, which is spread through all Africa — because, if they were tolerating some wicked men in their own neighbourhood whom they could not point out to the rest, they ought rather to have tolerated them than to divide themselves from so many innocent men, to whom they could not prove another's sins, even if they themselves knew them perfectly well? Why, then, is this innocence not granted to the whole world, in so great a multitude and breadth of nations, wherever the inheritance of Christ lies open, so that it is sure and secure that those who call themselves good and sunder themselves from the unity of the whole earth do, by that very fact, show what they are? For they seem just to themselves and despise the rest, and therefore do not sing the new song, because they are puffed up with the pride of the old man. From that communion indeed they are separated to which it was said: *sing to the Lord a new song, sing to the Lord, all the earth*. If they were truly just, they would also be humble; and if they were humble, then, even if they truly were tolerating wicked men in the assembly of their own neighbourhood whom they could not expel from the unity of Christ, they would choose to tolerate them out of the charity of Christ. But how can they have a just judgement about those very men whom they charge with being wicked in their own neighbourhood, when with rash blindness they accuse men, utterly unknown, set so far away from them? For whether they know that either their own fellow-citizens or their neighbours, whom they charge, are wicked, is uncertain to the whole world; but that they separate themselves, with rash blindness, from those [[p. 131]] whose life, set far off, they cannot know — that is certain to the whole world; and that, with praise of patience, the known wicked are tolerated, lest the unknown good be condemned — that is certain to the whole world. Wherefore the whole world judges securely that they are not good who divide themselves from the whole world, in whatever part of the world.

Psalmus contra partem Donati, vv. 105–116 — the transmarine judges (A.D. 393; CSEL 51, p. 7)

- 104 All you who rejoice in peace, now judge the truth.
- 105 If you wish to follow justice, consider the whole case.
- 106 What Donatus did afterward – why was it not done before?
- 107 The bishops were in disagreement throughout the whole African region:
- 108 the bishops across the sea could judge of the matter.
- 109 Why did you run to schism, and altar against altar,

110 so that what was afterward judged you could no longer hear,
111 and were forced to appeal from your own judges,
112 while you wish to establish the reign of error by any means
whatever?
113 And now you too know it all, but you pretend not to know,
114 and when the truth presses you, you say your fathers erred,
115 as though someone forbade you now to withdraw from the error.
116 But pride has bound you in the seat of pestilence.

Psalmus contra partem Donati, vv. 220–232 — count the bishops from Peter's see (p. 12)

220 You know what the catholic Church is, and what has been cut off
from the vine.
221 If any among you are prudent, let them come, let them live in the
root;
222 before they wither too far, let them now be delivered from the
fire.
223 We do not rebaptize, because the sign is one in the faith,
224 not because we see you to be holy, but [because you] hold the
form alone,
225 since the branch that has been cut from the vine has that very
form.
226 But what does the form profit it, if it does not live from the
root?
227 Come, brothers, if you will, to be grafted into the vine.
228 It is a grief when we see you, thus cut off, lying so.
229 Count the bishops even from the very see of Peter,
230 and in that order of the fathers see who succeeded whom:
231 that is the rock which the proud gates of hell do not overcome.
232 All you who rejoice in peace, now judge the truth.

Psalmus contra partem Donati, vv. 258–288 — the Mother-Church epilogue (pp. 14–15)

258 All you who rejoice in peace, now judge the truth.
259 Hear, brothers, what I say, and do not be angry with me.
260 For what you hear is not false; you can consider it too.
261 What if Mother Church herself should address you with peace
262 and say: 'O my children, why do you complain of your mother?
263 Why have you forsaken me? I now wish to hear it from you.
264 You accuse your brothers, and I am grievously torn.
265 When the nations were pressing me, I bore much with sorrow.
266 Many forsook me, but they did it in fear;
267 but you no one compelled thus to rebel against me.
268 You say that you are with me, but you see it to be false:
269 I am called catholic, and you are of the party of Donatus.
270 The apostle bade me pray for the kings of the world;

271 you are envious that the kings are now in the Christian faith.
 272 If you are sons, why do you envy that my prayers have been heard?
 273 For when they sent gifts, you were unwilling to accept them
 274 and forgot the prophets, who foretold this beforehand,
 275 that the great kings of the nations would send gifts to the
 Church.
 276 And when you spurned those gifts, you showed that you are not
 [mine]
 277 and forced Macarius to avenge his own grief.
 278 But what have I done to you, your mother in all the world?
 279 I expel the wicked whom I can; whom I cannot, I am forced to
 bear;
 280 I bear them, until they are healed or are separated at the end.
 281 Why have you abandoned me, and I am tormented over your death?
 282 If you hate the wicked so much, see what sort you have.
 283 If you too tolerate the wicked, why not within unity,
 [[p. 15]]
 284 where no one rebaptizes, nor is there altar against altar?
 285 You tolerate so many wicked men, but for no good reward,
 286 because what you owe for Christ's sake, you choose to bear for
 Donatus''.
 287 We have sung you peace, brothers, if you will hear.
 288 Our judge is to come: we give, he exacts.

De baptismo I.18.28 — Cyprian erred, yet remained in unity (c. 400/401; CSEL 51, pp. 170–173)

28. There exist, in the letters of the blessed martyr Cyprian, great proofs — so that I may now come to him of whose authority these men flatter themselves carnally, while by his charity they are spiritually undone. [[p. 171]] For in those times, before the sentence of a plenary council should confirm, by the agreement of the whole Church, what was to be followed in this matter, it seemed good to him, together with about eighty of his fellow bishops of the African churches, that every man who had been baptized outside the communion of the catholic Church ought, on coming to the Church, to be baptized anew. That this was not rightly done, the Lord assuredly did not reveal to so great a man, for this reason: that his piety, and his humility and charity in wholesomely preserving the peace of the Church, might be made manifest, and might be marked — as a medicinal lesson, so to say — not only for the Christians of his own time but also for those to come. For when a bishop of such merit, of such a Church, of such a heart, of such eloquence, of such virtue, held a view of baptism other than what the more diligently examined truth was going to establish, and when many of his colleagues, though not yet holding it as clearly manifested, nevertheless held that which both the earlier custom of the Church and afterward the whole catholic world embraced, he yet did not sunder himself, by a separated communion, from the rest who held a different view, and he did not cease to persuade the rest also to bear with one another in love, striving to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace. For thus, with the frame of the body remaining intact, if anything in certain members was ailing, it would rather grow well again from the health of the others than, killed off by amputation, admit the care of no healing. And if he had separated himself, how many would have followed! What a name he would have made for himself among men! How much more widely would they be called

Cyprianists than Donatists! But he was not a son of perdition, of whom it is said: *thou hast cast them down while they were being lifted up*, but he was a son of the Church's peace, who, endowed with such illumination of heart, [[p. 172]] for this reason did not see a certain thing, that through him something more surpassing might be seen. *And still*, says the apostle, *I show you a more surpassing way. If I speak with the tongues of men and of angels, but have not charity, I am become sounding brass or a tinkling cymbal*. Less, therefore, did he penetrate, to discern the hidden secret of the sacrament; but if he knew all sacraments and had not charity, he would be nothing. But when, perceiving that lesser thing less, he yet guarded this [charity] humbly, faithfully, bravely, he merited to attain the crown of martyrdom, so that, if any cloud out of the human condition had crept into his shining mind, it might be dispelled by the glorious serenity of his shining blood. For not in vain did the Lord Jesus Christ himself, when he called himself the vine and his own as it were the branches in the vine, say that they are cut off and taken away from the vine as useless branches which bear no fruit. And what is the fruit but that new offspring of which he likewise says: *a new commandment I give you, that you love one another*? This is that charity, without which the rest profit nothing. The apostle also says: *but the fruit of the Spirit is charity, joy, peace, long-suffering, kindness, goodness, faith, meekness, self-control*. All these begin from charity and, by the remaining conjunction, make as it were a wondrous cluster. Nor yet in vain did the same Lord add: *but the branches in me that bear fruit, my Father prunes them, that they may bear more fruit* — save that even they who prevail in the fruit of charity can nevertheless have something to be pruned, which the husbandman does not leave uncultivated. [[p. 173]] Therefore, that this holy man, thinking otherwise concerning baptism than the reality was — which was afterward, by handling and by most diligent consideration, established — remained in catholic unity, was both compensated by the abundance of his charity and pruned away by the pruning-hook of his passion.

De baptismo II.6.7–9 — ‘had the Church then already perished?’ (pp. 181–184)

- VI. 7. You, then, Donatists — what do you say to these things? If our view of baptism is true, all who thought otherwise in Cyprian's times were not separated from the unity of the Church, [[p. 182]] until God should reveal to them that which they thought otherwise. Why, then, have you, by a sacrilegious separation, broken the bond of peace? But if your view of baptism is true, Cyprian and the rest, with whom you allege that he held such a council, remained in unity with those who thought otherwise. Why have you broken the bond of peace? Whichever of these you choose, you are compelled to bring a sentence against your own severance. Answer: why did you separate? Why did you raise up an altar against the whole world? Why do you not communicate with the churches to which you hold that the apostolic epistles were sent, and which you read, and according to which you say you live? Answer: why did you separate? Assuredly for this reason: lest you should perish by the communion of the wicked. How, then, did Cyprian and so many of his colleagues not perish? For they, though they believed that heretics and schismatics did not have baptism — such being received nevertheless without baptism, and though they believed that sins so monstrous and so sacrilegious were upon them — chose rather to communicate with them than to be separated from unity, Cyprian saying: *judging no one, nor removing anyone from the right of communion if he has thought differently*.

8. If, then, by such communion of the wicked the just perish, then the Church had already perished in Cyprian's times. Whence, therefore, arose the origin of Donatus? Where was he catechized, where baptized, where ordained, when already the contagion of communion had extinguished the Church? But if there was a Church, the wicked could in no way have harmed the good in one communion. Why did you separate? Behold, in unity I see Cyprian and his other colleagues, who by a council held decreed that all who had been baptized outside the communion of the Church did not have baptism, and that therefore it must be given to them when they come. But [[p. 183]] behold, again, in the same unity I see certain men holding a different view on this matter, and, of those who had come from heretics or schismatics, not daring — when the baptism of Christ was recognized in them — to baptize them again. All these catholic unity embraces in her maternal bosom, as they bear one another's burdens and strive to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace, until the Lord should reveal to the one party of them, if they thought anything otherwise. If these thought the truth, were they not contaminated by those, or were they contaminated? If those thought the truth, were they not contaminated by these, or were they contaminated? Choose which you will. If they were contaminated, then already there was no Church. Answer: whence did you come forth hither? But if the Church remained, in no way are the good contaminated by the wicked in such communion. Answer: why did you break the bond?
9. Or perhaps schismatics received without baptism do not contaminate, but the betrayers of the holy books do contaminate? That your own men were betrayers, the most manifest records of the deeds attest. And if at that time you had been speaking the truth against those whom you accused, you would have persuaded the whole world of your cause, so that, you being retained, they might be excluded. But if you attempted to do this and did not obtain it, the whole world is innocent, which believed the ecclesiastical judges rather than the defeated litigants. But if you were unwilling to plead your cause, the whole world is innocent, which could not condemn men unheard. Why, then, did you separate yourselves from the innocent? You cannot defend the sacrilege of your schism. But I pass this over, and say this: if betrayers could contaminate you — who are not convicted by you, and by whom you are defeated — much more could the sacrileges of schismatics and heretics, received without baptism (according to your view), contaminate [[p. 184]] Cyprian. Yet he did not separate himself, and because the Church remained it is manifest that it could not be contaminated. Why, then, did you separate yourselves — I do not say from the innocent, which is proved, but from those very betrayers, which is not proved? Or, as I began to say, are the crimes of betrayers graver than those of schismatics? Let us not bring deceitful balances, where we may weigh what we wish and how we wish, saying by our own arbitrary judgement, 'this is grave, this is light,' but let us bring the divine balance from the Holy Scriptures, as from the Lord's treasures, and in it let us weigh what is graver — nay, let us not weigh, but recognize what has been weighed by the Lord. In that time when the Lord, by fresh examples of punishments, showed that former sins were to be guarded against — both an idol was fashioned and adored, and a prophetic book was burned by the wrath of a contemptuous king, and schism was attempted — idolatry was punished by the sword, the burning of the book by warlike slaughter and by captivity in a foreign land, schism by the gaping of the earth, its authors being buried alive and the rest consumed by heavenly fire. Who now would doubt that that was more wickedly committed which was more gravely avenged? Coming from such sacrileges without baptism — as you say — they did not contaminate Cyprian: how could betrayers, not convicted but fabricated, contaminate you? For they who had not merely handed over books to be burned, but

had burned them themselves with their own hands, would nevertheless have been of a lesser crime than if they committed schism, because the one was more mildly, the other more gravely avenged — not by human judgement, but by divine.

De baptismo V.2–4 — the honest hypothetical: ‘whichever of the two be true’ (pp. 263–266)

- II. 2. But now let us carry through what we have set out to do — to converse with the blessed Cyprian, a man of peace. He, when he had set before himself what he knew was said by the brethren — *what then shall become of those who in the past, coming from heresy to the Church, were admitted without baptism?* — says: *the Lord is able, in his mercy, to grant indulgence, and not to separate from the gifts of his Church those who, admitted to the Church in simplicity, have fallen asleep in the Church.* He presumed well, that the charity of unity could cover a multitude of sins. But if they had baptism, and it was not rightly held by those who thought they must be baptized anew, the charity of unity covered that error, so long as there was present in it not a diabolical dissension but a human trial, until the Lord, as the apostle says, should reveal to them if they thought anything otherwise. And therefore woe to those who, through a sacrilegious severance broken off from unity, if baptism is both among us and among them, rebaptize; but if it is in the catholic Church alone, do not baptize at all. Whether, then, they rebaptize or do not baptize, they are not in the bond of peace, whereby they might apply medicine to the wound of any of these. But we, if we admit to the Church without baptism, are in that number to whom Cyprian presumed that pardon could be granted for the sake of preserving unity. But if — as now, I think, from the things which [[p. 264]] we have said in the earlier books, is manifest — the integrity of Christian baptism can exist even in the perversity of heretics, then if any in those times rebaptized and yet did not withdraw from the frame of unity, they could, by the same love of peace, attain to pardon, whereby Cyprian testifies that even those admitted without baptism could not be separated from the gifts of the Church. Moreover, if it is true that among heretics and schismatics there is not the baptism of Christ, how much less would another's sins harm those set in unity, if for those coming to unity and admitted even without baptism their own sins too were loosed! For if, as Cyprian testifies, the bond of unity avails so much, how could they be harmed by another's sins who were unwilling to withdraw from unity, if even the unbaptized would not perish by their own sins, who wished to approach it from heresy?
- III. 3. But that which Cyprian adds and says — *yet not, because one has once erred, is one therefore always to err, since it befits the more wise and the God-fearing to obey readily and without hesitation the truth laid open and perceived, rather than obstinately and stubbornly to struggle against the brethren and fellow priests on behalf of heretics* — he says most truly; nor is he adverse to another rather than to himself who resists the most manifest truth. But by those things which we have now said in such number, it appears clearly, as I think, and it is certain, that the baptism of Christ cannot be violated by the perversity of heretics, when among them it is given and received. But even granting that it is not yet certain, that at least it is still doubtful — [[p. 265]] whoever, retaining also the things that have been said, shall consider, confesses [this]. We do not, then, resist the most manifest truth; but either we contend for the manifest truth, as I judge, or at least — as those can suppose who think this question not yet solved — we are still seeking the truth. And therefore, if the matter is otherwise than we say, with the same simplicity we receive those baptized by heretics, with

which those men received them whom, for the sake of unity, Cyprian presumed to attain to pardon. But if the baptism of Christ, as the many things now said indicate, can be whole even in one not whole in either life or faith — whether of those who seem to be within, yet do not belong to the members of that one dove, or of those who so do not belong to her as even to be openly outside — then those who in those times repeated it were earning the same pardon, for the sake of the charity of unity, which Cyprian believed those to have earned, for the sake of such charity, whom he judged to have been admitted without baptism. These men, therefore, who — with no cause existing (since, as the same Cyprian shows, the wicked cannot harm the good in unity) — cut themselves off from the charity of that same unity, have lost the place of all pardon; and though they should perish by the very crime of schism, even if after [entering] the catholic Church they did not rebaptize, of how great a punishment are they worthy, who either attempt to give to catholics, who have it, that which Cyprian affirms they do not have, or — as the matter itself shows — charge the catholic Church with not having that which they themselves also have!

- IV. 4. But since now, as I began to say, we have set out to converse with Cyprian's letters, I should not seem — not even to him, were he present — to struggle obstinately and stubbornly against the brethren and fellow priests on behalf of heretics, since he would accept these very things that move us: why we believe that even among heretics, perverted in their malignant error, the baptism of Christ can nevertheless, through its own self, be most reverend and most holy, [[p. 266]] and can be. And since he too himself testifies — whose testimony is of great weight for us — that they were wont in the past to be so admitted: let whoever, moved by his discourse, does not doubt that heretics are to be baptized anew, reckon those to whom this, on account of the many things urged against it, is not yet persuaded, to be such as were in the past those who admitted in simplicity men baptized in heresy, their own error alone being corrected, and who together with them were able to be saved through the bond of unity. But whoever — by the earlier custom of the Church, and by the later strength of a plenary council, and by so many and so great testimonies of the Holy Scriptures, and by the many proofs of Cyprian himself, and by clear reasons of the truth — understands that the baptism of Christ, consecrated by the words of the Gospel, is not made perverse by any man's perversity, let him understand, by the same bond of unity, that those could be saved to whom something else, with charity safe, then seemed [right]. And by this it must be understood, at once, that those whom no tares, no chaff, could defile — had they themselves willed to be wheat — within the fellowship of the Church spread throughout the whole world, and who therefore, with no cause existing, broke themselves off from that same bond of unity: whichever of the two be true, whether what Cyprian then held or what the catholic universality (from which he did not withdraw) obtained, they, being openly set outside in the manifest sacrilege of schism, cannot be saved; and all that they have of the divine sacraments and of the largess of one lawful man, so long as they are such, avails rather to their confusion than to their salvation.

Contra Gaudentium II.8.8–9 — Cyprian and Stephen of Rome, both in unity (A.D. 419; CSEL 53, pp. 264–265)

- VIII. 8. In vain, then, does it seem to you that the councils of Agrippinus and of Cyprian are to be followed in this question, since you yourselves neglected them, when you received those baptized outside your communion by condemned men — against whom you were litigating that they should be excluded from the basilicas

— without any repetition of baptism. But concerning the view of Cyprian, or of his colleagues, to whom it then seemed good that those coming from heretics ought to be baptized, it is a long matter for me to dispute as it deserves. But solve me, if you can, this brief question. When Cyprian, bishop of the church of Carthage, was rebaptizing those coming from heretics, at that time Stephen, bishop of the church of Rome, was receiving heretics in the same baptism which they had received outside, and both, doing these contrary things, remained in catholic unity: tell me, whether at that time the Church — when, according to you, it was receiving men guilty of all crimes without baptism, through Stephen and his innumerable colleagues throughout the whole world, who were sharers of the same view — had perished by the contagion of the wicked, or had not perished. For you cannot call those wicked men hidden, although you assert that even the hidden do harm and bring death. Whoever, therefore — a murderer, or even a parricide, an adulterer, a defiler, an idolater, and finally a not-timid betrayer of the holy books, or a cruel torturer that they might be handed over, and a violent extorter, and, by command or by hand, a final burner — being baptized among heretics, came to Stephen and his associates, was, according to you, received without baptism. You see, then, all the crimes of men — if what you hold concerning baptism is true — gathered then in a Church without baptism. Answer: whether by these crimes Cyprian was stained in that same unity; answer: whether the Church perished or did not perish. Choose what you will. If it had already perished then, who bore Donatus? But if, with so many gathered into it without baptism, it could not perish, answer, [[p. 265]] I beseech, what madness persuaded the party of Donatus to separate from it, as though shunning the communion of the wicked.

9. But far be it that, because the most blessed Cyprian thought otherwise concerning baptism than the truth — which he showed both by earlier custom and afterward by reason more diligently perceived — therefore any of us, who do not think this that he did, should dare to prefer himself to him. For his other merits, many and great, and his spirit most full of surpassing charity — through which he remained most peaceable with colleagues who thought differently — and his glorious passion in the unity of the Church, have sufficiently shown that he was a fruitful branch in the root of Christ, which the Father would prune even from this fault, that it might bear greater fruit. For thus Jesus himself says: *the branch that in me bears fruit, my Father prunes it, that it may bear more fruit* — showing that even in the fruitful ones the husbandman, who is in heaven, finds something to prune. For who of us can be compared to the apostle Peter, although we have never compelled the nations to Judaize, which he was doing when he was not walking rightly toward the truth of the Gospel? Whence, corrected by his later apostle Paul with a wholesome admonition, he furnished to posterity a more useful example of humility than if there had been nothing in him to be corrected.

Gesta cum Emerito 5 — the catholic bishops' conditional oath of 411 (CSEL 53, pp. 185–187)

5. Alypius, bishop of the catholic Church, read out a letter: To the honourable and most beloved son, the most illustrious and distinguished man, the tribune and notary Marcellinus, [from] Aurelius, Silvanus, and all the catholic bishops. By the edict of your Excellency, whereby provision has been made for preserving the tranquillity and quiet of our conference and for making manifest and safeguarding the truth, we signify by this letter that we agree in all things, as you have deigned to admonish.

Trusting, moreover, in the truth, we bind ourselves by a bond of condition: that, if those with whom we treat can show us that — when, according to God's promises, the Christian peoples, growing on every side, had already filled a great part of the world and were being extended into the rest still to be filled — the Church of Christ suddenly perished by the contagion of the sins (of I know not whom, whom these men accuse) and remained only in the party of Donatus: if, as has been said, they can show this, we will require no honours of the episcopate among them, but will follow, for our salvation alone, the counsel of those to whom we shall owe the grace of so great a benefit for the truth made known. But if [[p. 186]] we rather shall have availed to show that the Church of Christ — of all provinces not only African but also transmarine, already holding the most fertile expanses of many nations with an abundance of peoples, and, as it is written, *fructifying and growing in all the world* — could not perish by the sins of any men mingled into it; if, finally, we shall have proved that the question concerning those very men (whom they then wished to accuse rather than were able to convict) has been determined — though the Church does not consist in them — and that Caecilian was judged innocent, but they violent and slanderous, by that emperor to whose examination they of their own accord, by accusing, referred their charges; if, lastly, whatever they shall say concerning the sins of any men whatever, we shall have proved, either by human documents or by divine, either that their innocence was assailed by false charges, or that the Church of Christ, to whose communion we cleave, was destroyed by none of their offences: then let them so hold unity with us, that they may not only find the way of salvation, but not even lose the honour of the episcopate. For we detest in them not the sacraments of divine truth, but the fabrications of human error; and these being removed, we will embrace the brotherly heart joined to us by Christian charity, which we now grieve to see separated by diabolical dissension. For each of us will be able, with a colleague joined to him in honour, in turn to sit more eminently, as a colleague sitting beside a visiting bishop. This, when by alternate [[p. 187]] use of the basilicas it is granted on both sides, each preceding the other with mutual honour — because, where the precept of charity has enlarged hearts, the possession of peace does not become cramped — so that, when one of them has died, thenceforth single bishops may succeed single ones after the ancient manner. Nor will anything new be done; for this, from the very beginning of the separation, catholic love has preserved in those who, condemning the error of the wicked dissension, tasted (even if late) the sweetness of unity. Or if perhaps the Christian peoples are pleased with single bishops, and cannot bear the partnership of two by the unaccustomed novelty of the thing, let both of us withdraw from the midst; and, the cause of schism being condemned and the single churches established in peaceful unity, let single bishops be appointed — throughout the places where they are needed — by the single bishops who, in the single churches, consent to the unity that has been made.

De unico baptismo 16.28–30 — Miltiades' Roman judgment; the Church decoupled from her ministers' merits (c. 410/411; CSEL 53, pp. 29–32)

28. To this is added that, while Miltiades was then presiding as bishop of the Roman church, by the command of the emperor Constantine — to whom the accusers of Caecilian, bishop of the church of Carthage, had referred that whole cause through the proconsul Anullinus — the same Caecilian was pronounced innocent. And when the forefathers of these men, with most importunate obstinacy, complained to the said emperor about that judgement, that it had not been fully or rightly examined and brought out, they said nothing about the betrayal or the offering of incense by

Miltiades — to whose hearing they ought certainly not even to have come — suggesting rather to the emperor beforehand, or urging that it be suggested, that they ought not to plead their cause before a betrayer of the divine books and one defiled by sacrifices to idols. Since, therefore, they neither suggested this beforehand, nor, after it was judged against them for Caecilian, thought it worth objecting even when defeated and angry, why do they now, empty, so late knit together their slanders — as though by the discrediting of Miltiades the judge the innocence of Caecilian might be darkened, and the Roman church itself, where they were able neither to condemn anyone by any judgement of their own, nor to substitute any of their own, as it were, into [[p. 30]] the place of a condemned man — against which church they were furtively sending, from far off, adventitious interlopers to a very few Africans of their own party (whom this man was not ashamed to name individually), until the deceived little flock should ordain them as it were their own bishops? Indeed, after the clearing of Caecilian, they accused Felix, bishop of Aptunga, before the emperor, that he himself was a most manifest betrayer, and that therefore Caecilian could not be a bishop, because he had been ordained by that betrayer. Then Constantine did not deny a place to this accusation of theirs either, although he had found them slanderous in the fabricated charges against Caecilian, and therefore he commanded that the case of Felix be examined. In Africa it was examined by the proconsul Aelianus; Felix too was declared innocent. The proconsular records exist; whoever will, let him take and read them. And this pertains not only to the heaping-up of the demonstration of Caecilian's innocence, and to the most evident clearing of Felix himself, and to the exposing of the slanders of those who had called him the fountain of all the evils in their council, but also to the considering of the most pure life of Miltiades against their accusations. Unless perhaps anyone were so foolish as to believe that they, when they did not spare Felix, by whom Caecilian had been ordained, could have spared Miltiades, by whom he had been absolved, if they could have censured the life of that bishop — even though no wound had destroyed his conscience — at least by some rumour. Or was it that what had been fabricated concerning the forum of Aptunga [[p. 31]] should be charged by these men, while what had been done in the Capitol of the Romans should be passed over in silence?

29. But concerning Mensurius, what shall I answer, since in his time, up to the day of his death, the people of unity was in no way rent, and the very letters of Secundus of Tigisis — by which he is asserted to have been reproved — confirm that they wrote to one another peaceably and remained in the fellowship of the college? And now, as to what he chose to say also about the church of Cirta, and inveighed with abuse against the catholic bishops there whom he wished, what else did he do but, by reviling holy men even of our own times, and very well known to us, sufficiently show what we ought to think even about the unknown, whom he likewise reviles? Accordingly, if Profuturus, deceased a very few years ago, and Fortunatus, who is still in the body and succeeded him as bishop, were Manichaeans in the same way as those men were betrayers — whom, most unknown, far from our times, they do not cease to accuse — then their life, pure from the reproaches of these men, is now very well known to us.
30. Not small, indeed, and not inglorious, is the consolation of any of us, if we are accused by the enemies of the Church together with the Church herself; yet her defence does not consist in the defence of those men whom these people assail by name with false accusations. Assuredly, whatever Marcellinus, Marcellus, Silvester, Miltiades, Mensurius, Caecilian, and the others may have been — against whom they object, out of their dissension, what they will — they prejudge nothing against [[p. 32]] the catholic Church spread throughout the whole world; in no way are we crowned by their innocence, in no way are we condemned by their iniquity. If they

were good, in the threshing of the catholic floor they were cleansed as grains; if they were evil, in the threshing of the catholic floor they were crushed as stubble. Within this floor both good and evil can be; outside it the good cannot be. Whoever is separated from this unity by the wind of pride, as chaff alone — why does he slander the Lord's floor on account of the chaff mixed in?